

Core Templates — High-Level Reference

The single most generic, abstract template for each question type — the reusable skeleton you adapt per problem. Worked solutions, quick-reference tables, and the full problem index live in `template.md` / each category file.

Conventions, Skeleton & Core API

Two Pointers `two_pointers.md`

Two patterns — pick based on whether pointers converge or march together.

Pattern 1 — Opposite Two Pointers

```
// MENTAL MODEL: two ends close in on the answer; each comparison rules out one whole end of the range.
// WHY sorted: moving inward only safely eliminates half the space if the array is sorted
int i = 0, j = n - 1;
while (i < j) {
    if (condition == target) {
        /* record */ i++; j--;
    } else if (tooSmall) {
        i++;
    } else {
        j--;
    }
}
```

Sort first. `i` and `j` converge inward. Used when the array is sorted and you can eliminate half the search space each step.

Sliding Window `sliding_window.md`

Three variants — pick by what the problem asks for.

`i` = left boundary (inclusive), `j` = right boundary (loop variable, inclusive).

Window = `[i, j]`, size = `j - i + 1`.

The Three Templates

```
// FIXED window of size k – shrink exactly once when full
// a constant-width window slides one step at a time; add the new cell, drop the old one. – WHEN: "sub
int i = 0;
for (int j = 0; j < n; j++) {
    // 1. add nums[j] to state
    if (j - i + 1 == k) {
        // 2. record (window is exactly size k)
        // 3. remove nums[i] from state
        i++;
    }
}

// MAX variable window – find LONGEST valid window
// grow greedily; shrink only enough to restore validity, then the window is the best ending here. – W
int i = 0, result = 0;
for (int j = 0; j < n; j++) {
    // 1. add nums[j] to state
    while (/* window exceeds constraint */) { // shrink WHILE window exceeds constraint
        // remove nums[i] from state
        i++;
    }
    result = Math.max(result, j - i + 1); // record after window is valid
}

// MIN variable window – find SHORTEST valid window
// grow until valid, then shrink aggressively while still valid to find the tightest fit. – WHEN: "sho
int i = 0, result = Integer.MAX_VALUE;
for (int j = 0; j < n; j++) {
    // 1. add nums[j] to state
    while (/* window VALID */) { // record then shrink WHILE window still valid
        result = Math.min(result, j - i + 1); // record while valid
        // remove nums[i] from state
        i++; // then try to shrink
    }
}
```

Frequency Map Trick (used by 567 and 76)

Both use a `need[]` array and a `required` counter to avoid scanning the map each step.

```
// Expanding j – add s.charAt(j):
if (need[s.charAt(j)]-- > 0) required--; // was needed → satisfied one more

// Shrinking i – remove s.charAt(i):
if (need[s.charAt(i)]++ >= 0) required++; // was 0 (used up) → now short one
i++;
```

`need[c]` is positive when still needed, zero or negative when excess.

`required` reaches 0 exactly when all characters of `t` are covered.

Prefix Sum + HashMap `prefix_sum_hashmap.md`

Core idea: subarray sum $[l, r] = \text{prefix}[r+1] - \text{prefix}[l]$.

To find a subarray with a target property, rephrase as: "has a prefix with value `X` been seen before?"

Store that `X` in a HashMap for $O(1)$ lookup.

Core Template

```
// a subarray is the difference of two prefixes; remember prefixes seen so far and look up the compleme
Map<Long, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
map.put(0L, ???);    // seed: empty prefix (sum=0) seen before index 0
long sum = 0;
// result = 0 (count) or Integer.MAX_VALUE (length sentinel) depending on problem

for (int i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
    sum += nums[i];
    long lookup = transform(sum);    // what to look up (sum-k, sum%k, etc.)
    // use map.get(lookup) → update result
    map.put(storeKey(sum), storeValue(i)); // what to store (sum or sum%k → count or index)
}
```

What changes per problem:

Variable	Count problems (560, 974)	Length problems (325, 523)
Map value	count (how many times seen)	first index (earliest occurrence)
Seed value	map.put(0L, 1)	map.put(0L, -1)
On lookup hit	count += map.get(lookup)	maxLen = max(i - map.get(lookup))
Overwrite map?	Yes (merge count)	No (keep first index only)

Binary Search binary_search.md

Binary search appears in two forms: searching an **array index**, or searching an **answer value**.

The Only Template — [i, j), find first k with condition(k)

There is one binary search. Define a monotone condition(k) (false...false TRUE...true); the loop returns the **first k where condition(k) is true**. Then look at i: if i == n no index qualified, otherwise i is the boundary — check the value to decide.

```
int i = 0, j = nums.length;    // [i, j)
// find first k that meets condition(k)
while (i < j) {
    int k = i + (j - i) / 2;
    if (!condition(k)) {        // condition false → answer is strictly to the right
        i = k + 1;
    } else {                    // condition true → k might be the answer
        j = k;
    }
}
// i in [0, nums.length]; if i == nums.length, no k met condition(k)
```

Pick condition(k) :

Want	condition(k)	Answer after loop
lowerBound — first $\geq$ target	<code>nums[k] $\geq$ target</code>	<code>i</code>
upperBound — first $>$ target	<code>nums[k] $>$ target</code>	<code>i</code>
exact search (#704)	<code>nums[k] $\geq$ target</code>	<code>i < n && nums[i] == target ? i : -1</code>
insert position (#35)	<code>nums[k] $\geq$ target</code>	<code>i</code>
first / last occurrence (#34)	<code>$\geq$ then $>$</code>	<code>lowerBound , upperBound - 1</code>
count of target	—	<code>upperBound - lowerBound</code>
minimize feasible X	<code>feasible(k)</code> over value range	<code>i</code>
maximize feasible X	<code>!feasible(k)</code> (first infeasible)	<code>i - 1</code>

The rule: the answer is always `i`. Guard `i == nums.length` (nothing met the condition) before reading `nums[i]`, then confirm the value.

How to Choose

Signal	condition(k)
Sorted array, find exact value	<code>arr[k] $\geq$ target</code> , then check <code>arr[i] == target</code>
Insert position / first occurrence	<code>arr[k] $\geq$ target</code> $\rightarrow$ return <code>i</code> (<code>= lowerBound</code>)
Last occurrence / count	<code>arr[k] $>$ target</code> (<code>= upperBound</code>); <code>last = upperBound - 1</code> , <code>count = upper - lower</code>
Rotated / peak slope search	<code>condition(k)</code> compares <code>arr[k]</code> to a neighbor or endpoint
"minimum X such that feasible(X)"	<code>condition(k) = feasible(k)</code> over value range $\rightarrow$ return <code>i</code>
"maximum X such that feasible(X)"	<code>condition(k) = !feasible(k)</code> over <code>[lo, hi+1)</code> $\rightarrow$ return <code>i - 1</code>

The one rule: define `condition(k)` so it is monotone `false...false TRUE...true`, then the answer is the first `k` that flips it true (`j = k` on true, `i = k + 1` on false). For MAXIMIZE, make the condition "first infeasible" and subtract 1 — same loop, no ceiling mid.

Sorting `sorting.md`

All recursive sorting uses **half-open intervals** `[start, end)` throughout.
Inside merge and partition: `i`, `j`, `k` as scan/write pointers (consistent with binary search convention).

Template 1 – Merge Sort

```
// split in half until trivially sorted, then merge two sorted halves into one. – WHEN: need stable so
// Entry point
public void mergeSort(int[] nums) {
    mergeSort(nums, 0, nums.length, new int[nums.length]);
}

// [start, end) half-open
private void mergeSort(int[] nums, int start, int end, int[] temp) {
    if (end - start <= 1) return; // base case: end - start <= 1 → 0 or 1 elements, already sort
    int mid = start + (end - start) / 2;
    mergeSort(nums, start, mid, temp); // sort [start, mid)
    mergeSort(nums, mid, end, temp); // sort [mid, end)
    merge(nums, start, mid, end, temp);
}

// i scans left [start,mid), j scans right [mid,end), k writes to temp
private void merge(int[] nums, int start, int mid, int end, int[] temp) {
    int i = start, j = mid, k = start;
    while (i < mid || j < end) {
        if (j >= end || (i < mid && nums[i] <= nums[j])) {
            temp[k++] = nums[i++];
        } else {
            temp[k++] = nums[j++];
        }
    }
    for (i = start; i < end; i++) nums[i] = temp[i];
}
```

Template 2 — Quick Sort (3-way Dutch Flag Partition)

```
// pick a pivot, partition into <pivot | ==pivot | >pivot, recurse on the two ends only. - WHEN: in-pl
// Entry point - no extra array needed (in-place)
public void quickSort(int[] nums) {
    quickSort(nums, 0, nums.length);
}

// [start, end) half-open
private void quickSort(int[] nums, int start, int end) {
    if (end - start <= 1) return;
    int pivot = nums[start + (end - start) / 2];
    int i = start, k = start, j = end - 1;
    // Invariant: [start,i) < pivot | [i,k) == pivot | [k,j) unknown | (j,end) > pivot
    while (k <= j) {
        if (nums[k] < pivot) {
            swap(nums, k++, i++);
        } else if (nums[k] == pivot) {
            k++;
        } else {
            swap(nums, k, j--);
        }
    }
    // After: [start,i) < pivot, [i,k) == pivot, [k,end) > pivot
    quickSort(nums, start, i); // recurse on < region
    quickSort(nums, k, end); // recurse on > region
}

private void swap(int[] nums, int i, int j) {
    int t = nums[i]; nums[i] = nums[j]; nums[j] = t;
}
```

Template 3 — Quick Select (partial sort — k-th element)

Extends quick sort: after partition, only recurse into the side that contains `target` index.

```
// same partition as quick sort, but recurse into only the one side holding target → O(n) avg. - WHEN:
// Returns value at 0-indexed position target after sorting
private int quickSelect(int[] nums, int start, int end, int target) {
    int pivot = nums[start + (end - start) / 2];
    int i = start, k = start, j = end - 1;
    while (k <= j) {
        if (nums[k] < pivot) {
            swap(nums, k++, i++);
        } else if (nums[k] == pivot) {
            k++;
        } else {
            swap(nums, k, j--);
        }
    }
    // [start,i) < pivot, [i,k) == pivot, [k,end) > pivot
    if (target < i) {
        return quickSelect(nums, start, i, target);
    } else if (target < k) {
        return pivot; // target lands in == region
    } else {
        return quickSelect(nums, k, end, target);
    }
}
```

Template 4 – Counting Sort

$O(n + \text{range})$. Use when values are bounded integers.

```
// tally how many times each value occurs, then emit values in order – no comparisons. – WHEN: integer
public void countingSort(int[] arr) {
    if (arr.length == 0) return;
    int min = Arrays.stream(arr).min().getAsInt();
    int max = Arrays.stream(arr).max().getAsInt();
    int[] buckets = new int[max - min + 1];
    for (int x : arr) buckets[x - min]++;
    int i = 0;
    for (int v = 0; v < buckets.length; v++)
        while (buckets[v]-- > 0) arr[i++] = v + min;
}
```

Linked List `linked_list.md`

Four patterns cover almost every linked list problem.
Consistent naming throughout: `sentinel`, `previous`, `current`, `next`, `slow`, `fast`.

When to Use – Signal → Pattern

Signal in the prompt	Pattern
"remove / delete / skip" nodes by value or duplicate	Delete / Filter (sentinel + <code>previous</code>)
"reverse" the list, a sub-range, or in k-groups	Reversal
"middle node", "cycle", "nth node from the end"	Fast / Slow
"merge two sorted lists" (or k lists)	Merge (sentinel + heap for k)
chained steps ("reorder", "palindrome", "sort")	Composite (combine the above)

All Four Templates

```
// 1. DELETE / FILTER - sentinel guards head removal; previous tracks last kept node
// previous always points at the last node you decided to keep, so re-wiring it skips anything unwanted
ListNode sentinel = new ListNode(0);
sentinel.next = head;
ListNode previous = sentinel, current = head;
while (current != null) {
    if (shouldDelete(current)) {
        previous.next = current.next;    // skip node
    } else {
        previous = current;              // keep node, advance previous
    }
    current = current.next;
}
return sentinel.next;

// 2. REVERSAL - re-wire one node at a time
// flip each arrow to point backward; previous is the growing reversed list trailing behind current. -
ListNode previous = null, current = head;
while (current != null) {
    ListNode next = current.next;    // save before overwrite
    current.next = previous;         // reverse pointer
    previous = current;              // advance
    current = next;
}
return previous; // new head

// 3. FAST / SLOW - two pointers at different speeds
// fast covers twice the distance, so when it hits the end slow is exactly halfway; in a loop they must
ListNode slow = head, fast = head;
while (fast != null && fast.next != null) {
    slow = slow.next;
    fast = fast.next.next;
}
// slow is at middle (or cycle detection: slow == fast → cycle found)

// 4. MERGE - sentinel collects nodes from two lists in order
// repeatedly splice the smaller head onto a growing result tail, like a zipper. - WHEN: "merge two (o
ListNode sentinel = new ListNode(0);
ListNode current = sentinel;
while (a != null && b != null) {
    if (a.val <= b.val) {
        current.next = a;
        a = a.next;
    } else {
        current.next = b;
        b = b.next;
    }
    current = current.next;
}
current.next = (a != null) ? a : b;
return sentinel.next;
```

`previous` stays on the last **kept** node. When deleting, re-wire `previous.next` to skip `current`. When keeping, advance `previous` to `current`. Always advance `current`.

String `string.md`

Core idioms first, then problems grouped by pattern.

For sliding window string problems (#3, #76, #567, #424), see `sliding_window.md` .

Core Idioms

```
// a lowercase string is a length-26 frequency vector; most string problems are vector ops on it. - WH
// 1. CHAR COUNT - lowercase letters
int[] count = new int[26];
// WHY ch - 'a': ASCII 'a'=97, so 'a'→0, 'b'→1, ..., 'z'→25 - a clean 0-25 bucket index into count[].
for (char ch : s.toCharArray()) count[ch - 'a']++; // ← ch - 'a' maps a→0, b→1, ..., z→25

// 2. CHAR COUNT - digits 0-9
int[] count = new int[10];
for (char ch : s.toCharArray()) count[ch - '0']++; // ← ch - '0' maps '0'→0, '9'→9

// 3. CHAR TO INTEGER - build number digit by digit
int num = 0;
for (int i = 0; i < s.length(); i++)
    num = num * 10 + (s.charAt(i) - '0'); // ← shift left × 10, add new digit

// 4. ANAGRAM HASH KEY - frequency-based (bucket sort style) O(k) vs sort O(k log k)
// WHY it works: anagrams share identical letter frequencies, so encoding the frequency vector
// ITSELF gives a unique key for the whole group - O(k) to build vs O(k log k) to sort the chars.
String hashKey(String s) {
    int[] count = new int[26];
    for (char ch : s.toCharArray()) count[ch - 'a']++;
    StringBuilder builder = new StringBuilder();
    for (int i = 0; i < 26; i++) {
        builder.append((char)('a' + i)); // ← letter as label
        builder.append(count[i]);       // ← its count
    }
    return builder.toString(); // e.g., "a2b0c1...z0"
}
// Alternative: sort the characters (simpler, slightly slower)
char[] chars = s.toCharArray();
Arrays.sort(chars);
String key = new String(chars); // anagrams → same sorted key

// 5. BUCKET SORT - sort by frequency without comparison sort
int[] count = new int[128]; // ASCII
for (char ch : s.toCharArray()) count[ch]++;
List<Character>[] buckets = new List[s.length() + 1]; // index = frequency
for (int i = 0; i < 128; i++) {
    if (count[i] > 0) {
        int freq = count[i];
        if (buckets[freq] == null) buckets[freq] = new ArrayList<>();
        buckets[freq].add((char) i);
    }
}
StringBuilder builder = new StringBuilder();
for (int freq = buckets.length - 1; freq > 0; freq--) { // ← descending frequency
    if (buckets[freq] == null) continue;
    for (char ch : buckets[freq])
        for (int i = 0; i < freq; i++) builder.append(ch);
}

// 6. EXPAND FROM CENTER - palindrome check in O(1) space
int expand(String s, int i, int j) { // i == j: odd length; i+1 == j: even length
    while (i >= 0 && j < s.length() && s.charAt(i) == s.charAt(j)) { i--; j++; }
    return j - i - 1; // ← length of palindrome found
}
```

Stack / Queue / Heap `stack_queue.md`

Four data structures — each with a canonical template and representative problems.

All Templates

```
// 1. STACK (LIFO) – use ArrayDeque, not Stack class
Deque<Integer> stack = new ArrayDeque<>();
stack.push(x);      // add to top
stack.pop();        // remove from top
stack.peek();       // view top, no remove

// 2A. MONOTONE DECREASING STACK – next GREATER element
// keep only candidates still waiting for a bigger neighbor; current resolves them all. – WHEN: "next/"
// Invariant: stack values decrease from bottom to top
// Pop when current is GREATER than top → top found its next greater
Deque<Integer> stack = new ArrayDeque<>(); // stores indices
for (int i = 0; i < n; i++) {
    while (!stack.isEmpty() && nums[stack.peek()] < nums[i])
        result[stack.pop()] = nums[i]; // nums[i] is next greater for popped index
    stack.push(i);
}
// Remaining in stack: no next greater element exists

// 2B. MONOTONE INCREASING STACK – next SMALLER element / span width
// each popped bar's reach extends until something shorter blocks it on both sides. – WHEN: "largest r
// Invariant: stack values increase from bottom to top
// Pop when current is SMALLER than top → use popped index to compute width/span
Deque<Integer> stack = new ArrayDeque<>(); // stores indices
for (int i = 0; i < n; i++) {
    while (!stack.isEmpty() && nums[stack.peek()] > nums[i]) {
        int height = nums[stack.pop()];
        int width = stack.isEmpty() ? i : i - stack.peek() - 1; // span between boundaries
        // process height * width
    }
    stack.push(i);
}

// 3. MONOTONE DEQUE – sliding window max/min
// the front is the current window's answer; anything a newer-and-bigger value beats is dead weight. –
// Deque stores INDICES; values at those indices are decreasing front-to-back (for max)
Deque<Integer> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
for (int i = 0; i < n; i++) {
    while (!queue.isEmpty() && nums[queue.peekLast()] <= nums[i])
        queue.pollLast(); // remove smaller elements – they can never be window max
    queue.offerLast(i);
    if (queue.peekFirst() < i - k + 1) queue.pollFirst(); // evict out-of-window elements
    if (i >= k - 1) result[i - k + 1] = nums[queue.peekFirst()];
}

// 4. PRIORITY QUEUE
PriorityQueue<Integer> minPQ = new PriorityQueue<>(); // min-heap (default)
PriorityQueue<Integer> maxPQ = new PriorityQueue<>(Collections.reverseOrder()); // max-heap
PriorityQueue<int[]> pq = new PriorityQueue<>((a, b) -> a[1] - b[1]); // custom: sort by index 1
pq.offer(x); // add
pq.poll(); // remove and return min/max
pq.peek(); // view min/max without removing

// 5. TWO HEAPS – maintain median in O(log n)
// split the data at the median; the median is always sitting on the two heaps' tops. – WHEN: "running
// maxHeap = lower half (smaller numbers), minHeap = upper half (larger numbers)
// Invariant: maxHeap.size() == minHeap.size() or maxHeap.size() == minHeap.size() + 1
PriorityQueue<Integer> maxHeap = new PriorityQueue<>(Collections.reverseOrder());
PriorityQueue<Integer> minHeap = new PriorityQueue<>();
void addNum(int num) {
    maxHeap.offer(num);
    minHeap.offer(maxHeap.poll()); // push one to minHeap (possibly num itself)
```

```
    if (maxHeap.size() < minHeap.size())
        maxHeap.offer(minHeap.poll());           // rebalance: maxHeap always ≥ minHeap in size
}
double findMedian() {
    return maxHeap.size() > minHeap.size()
        ? maxHeap.peek()
        : (maxHeap.peek() + minHeap.peek()) / 2.0;
}
```

BFS (Tree) bfs.md

Core structure: `Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>()` .
One template: snapshot the level size, then drain exactly that many nodes per level.

The Template — Level-Aware BFS

```
// LEVEL-AWARE PROCESSING — snapshot size to make per-level decisions
// the queue holds exactly one full level; freeze its size, then drain just that many. — WHEN: "level
Queue<TreeNode> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
queue.offer(root);
int level = 0;
while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
    int size = queue.size();           // ← snapshot: all nodes currently in queue = this level
    level++;
    for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
        TreeNode node = queue.poll();
        // process node (know: level, i==0 → first, i==size-1 → last)
        if (node.left != null) queue.offer(node.left);
        if (node.right != null) queue.offer(node.right);
    }
}
```

Always snapshot `size` first — it's how you know where each level ends. (If you truly don't need levels, just drop the `size` loop and poll node-by-node.)

When to Use — Signal → Pattern

Problem signal phrase	Pattern / group
"level order", "values per level", "each row"	Group 1 — collect entire level
"average / max / sum of each level"	Group 2 — aggregate per level
"right side view" (last in level), "bottom-left" (first in level)	Group 2 — record boundary node (<code>i==size-1</code> / <code>i==0</code>)
"minimum depth", "first level that satisfies X"	Group 3 — early return on condition
"connect next pointers at the same level"	Group 4 — wire nodes within a level
"same depth, different parent" (cousins), per-node metadata	Group 5 — track per-node metadata
"maximum width of a level" (counting null gaps)	Group 6 — position indexing

The One Rule — Snapshot Level Size First

Always snapshot the level size BEFORE the inner for loop:

```
int size = queue.size();
for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) { ... }
```

Without the snapshot, newly added children mix with the current level and `i == size-1 / i == 0` checks become meaningless.

DFS / Backtracking dfs.md

DFS appears in five forms. The pattern determines naming, return type, and where the answer is built.

When to Use — Signal → Pattern

Problem signal phrase	Pattern / template
"height / depth / sum OF the subtree", combine results upward	#1 Process children first, combine at node (post-order)
"root-to-leaf path", "number built along the path"	#2 Process node first, pass state down (pre-order)
"longest/best path that may bend through a node" (spans both arms)	#3 Tree global answer
"count islands / largest region / flood fill" on a grid	#4 Grid DFS
"can finish all", "detect cycle", "valid course order" (directed)	#5 Graph DFS 3-color
"all subsets / permutations / combinations", "find every way"	#6 Backtracking
"valid BST", "kth smallest", "closest value", "successor"	BST templates (pass bounds / inorder / binary search)

All Templates

```
// 1. PROCESS CHILDREN FIRST, COMBINE AT NODE (post-order)
// each node trusts its children to return a finished answer, then merges them. - WHEN: "what is the h
private int dfs(TreeNode node) {
    if (node == null) return BASE;           // 0 for depth, true for balanced
    int left = dfs(node.left);
    int right = dfs(node.right);
    // combine left, right, node.val → answer propagates up
    return ...;
}

// 2. PROCESS NODE FIRST, PASS STATE DOWN (pre-order)
// carry what you've seen so far down the path; the leaf has the full picture. - WHEN: "root-to-leaf p
private void dfs(TreeNode node, int accumulated) {
    if (node == null) return;
    accumulated += node.val;                 // update state on way down
    if (isLeaf(node)) { /* record */ return; }
    dfs(node.left, accumulated);
    dfs(node.right, accumulated);
    // backtrack: no undo needed for primitive; undo List.add if using collection
}

// 3. TREE - GLOBAL ANSWER (return up the best single arm; update global across both arms)
// the answer may bend through a node using both arms, but only one arm can extend upward. - WHEN: use
int answer = Integer.MIN_VALUE;
private int dfs(TreeNode node) {
    if (node == null) return 0;
    int left = Math.max(0, dfs(node.left)); // clamp negative
    int right = Math.max(0, dfs(node.right));
    answer = Math.max(answer, left + right + node.val); // cross-node path
    return Math.max(left, right) + node.val;           // single arm up
}

// 4. GRID DFS - mark visited by mutating grid; 4-directional flood fill
// stand on a cell, flood into all 4 neighbors, sinking each as you visit it. - WHEN: "connected regio
private void dfs(int[][] grid, int r, int c) {
    if (r < 0 || r >= grid.length || c < 0 || c >= grid[0].length) return;
    if (grid[r][c] != TARGET) return;
    grid[r][c] = VISITED;
    dfs(grid, r+1, c); dfs(grid, r-1, c);
    dfs(grid, r, c+1); dfs(grid, r, c-1);
}

// 5. GRAPH DFS - 3-color visited: 0=unseen 1=in-stack 2=done
// if you re-enter a node still on the current stack, you've looped back → cycle. - WHEN: "can finish
int[] state;
private boolean dfs(int node) {
    if (state[node] == 1) return true;      // back edge → cycle
    if (state[node] == 2) return false;     // already safe
    state[node] = 1;
    for (int neighbor : graph.get(node))
        if (dfs(neighbor)) return true;
    state[node] = 2;
    return false;
}

// 6. BACKTRACKING - choose / recurse / undo
// build a candidate one element at a time; undo each choice to explore the next branch. - WHEN: "all
private void backtrack(int start, List<Integer> current) {
    if (baseCase) { result.add(new ArrayList<>(current)); return; }
    for (int i = start; i < n; i++) {
        if (skipCondition(i)) continue;     // prune duplicates
    }
}
```

```

        current.add(nums[i]);           // choose
        backtrack(next, current);       // next = i (reuse) or i+1 (no reuse)
        current.remove(current.size()-1); // undo
    }
}

```

Graph graph.md

Queue<Integer> queue = new ArrayDeque<>() throughout.

Six algorithms — each with a canonical template and representative problems.

Complexity Legend

BFS / DFS	$O(V + E)$	visit each vertex and edge once
Topo sort (Kahn)	$O(V + E)$	each node enqueued once, each edge relaxed once
Union-Find	$\sim O(n \cdot \alpha(n)) \approx O(n)$	α = inverse Ackermann, effectively constant
Dijkstra	$O((V + E) \log V)$	non-negative weights ONLY

Graph Representation

```

// Adjacency list (most common)
List<List<Integer>> graph = new ArrayList<>();
for (int i = 0; i < n; i++) graph.add(new ArrayList<>());
for (int[] edge : edges) {
    graph.get(edge[0]).add(edge[1]);
    graph.get(edge[1]).add(edge[0]); // omit for directed
}

// Weighted adjacency list: int[] = {neighbor, weight}
List<List<int[]>> graph = new ArrayList<>();
for (int i = 0; i < n; i++) graph.add(new ArrayList<>());
for (int[] edge : edges)
    graph.get(edge[0]).add(new int[]{edge[1], edge[2]});

// Grid 4-directional neighbors
int[] dr = {1, -1, 0, 0};
int[] dc = {0, 0, 1, -1};

```


Core Templates

```
// 1. BFS – shortest path / level order (track distance by level-size snapshot)
// explore in rings of equal distance; snapshot the level size so each ring = one step. – WHEN: "fewes
Queue<Integer> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
boolean[] visited = new boolean[n];
queue.offer(start);
visited[start] = true;
int level = 0;
while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
    int size = queue.size(); // ← snapshot: all nodes at this distance
    for (int i = 0; i < size; i++) {
        int node = queue.poll();
        // process node (distance == level)
        for (int neighbor : graph.get(node)) {
            if (!visited[neighbor]) {
                visited[neighbor] = true;
                queue.offer(neighbor);
            }
        }
    }
    level++;
}

// 2. TOPOLOGICAL SORT – Kahn's BFS
// peel off nodes with no remaining prerequisites; if any get stuck, a cycle exists. – WHEN: "valid or
int[] inDegree = new int[n];
for (int[] edge : edges) inDegree[edge[1]]++;
Queue<Integer> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
for (int i = 0; i < n; i++) if (inDegree[i] == 0) queue.offer(i);
List<Integer> order = new ArrayList<>();
while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
    int node = queue.poll();
    order.add(node);
    for (int neighbor : graph.get(node))
        if (--inDegree[neighbor] == 0) queue.offer(neighbor);
}
// order.size() == n → no cycle

// 3. UNION FIND
// each set points to one representative; merge sets by linking roots, query by finding roots. – WHEN:
int[] parent, rank;
void init(int n) {
    parent = new int[n]; rank = new int[n];
    for (int i = 0; i < n; i++) parent[i] = i;
}
int find(int x) {
    if (parent[x] != x) parent[x] = find(parent[x]); // path compression
    return parent[x];
}
boolean union(int x, int y) {
    int px = find(x), py = find(y);
    if (px == py) return false;
    if (rank[px] < rank[py]) { int t = px; px = py; py = t; }
    parent[py] = px;
    if (rank[px] == rank[py]) rank[px]++;
    return true;
}

// 4. DIJKSTRA – shortest path (non-negative weights)
// greedily settle the closest unfinished node; non-negative weights guarantee it's final. – WHEN: "sh
int[] dist = new int[n];
Arrays.fill(dist, Integer.MAX_VALUE);
```

```

dist[src] = 0;
PriorityQueue<int[]> pq = new PriorityQueue<>((a, b) -> a[1] - b[1]); // min-heap on cost
pq.offer(new int[]{src, 0});
while (!pq.isEmpty()) {
    int[] current = pq.poll();
    int node = current[0], d = current[1];
    if (d > dist[node]) continue; // stale entry
    for (int[] nb : graph.get(node)) {
        int next = nb[0], w = nb[1];
        if (dist[node] + w < dist[next]) {
            dist[next] = dist[node] + w;
            pq.offer(new int[]{next, dist[next]});
        }
    }
}

// 5. BIPARTITE CHECK – BFS 2-coloring
// paint neighbors the opposite color; a neighbor that's already your color means an odd cycle. – WHEN
int[] color = new int[n];
Arrays.fill(color, -1);
Queue<Integer> queue = new ArrayDeque<>();
for (int start = 0; start < n; start++) {
    if (color[start] != -1) continue;
    color[start] = 0;
    queue.offer(start);
    while (!queue.isEmpty()) {
        int node = queue.poll();
        for (int neighbor : graph.get(node)) {
            if (color[neighbor] == -1) { color[neighbor] = 1 - color[node]; queue.offer(neighbor); }
            else if (color[neighbor] == color[node]) return false; // conflict
        }
    }
}
return true;

```

Greedy greedy.md

Two interval templates plus non-interval greedy patterns.

Two Interval Templates

MERGE DIRECTION RULE (for merge-style problems like #56, where both keys work):

Sort by START → traverse FORWARD ($i = 0 \rightarrow n-1$), extend the END of last kept

Sort by END → traverse BACKWARD ($i = n-1 \rightarrow 0$), extend the START of last kept

These two are exact mirror images. See #56 for both written out side by side.

(NOTE: this mirror only applies to merging. Template 1 below sorts by end but still sweeps FORWARD – there the goal is counting, not merging.)

TEMPLATE 1 – Sort by END time, sweep forward, track end of last kept interval

Use when: maximizing count of non-overlapping intervals

Greedy insight: earliest-finishing interval leaves most room for future ones

TEMPLATE 2 – Sort by START time, sweep forward, merge when overlapping

Use when: merging/counting overlapping intervals

Greedy insight: processing in start order → each interval only needs to compare with the last merged result

```

// sort to expose a local greedy choice, then sweep once making the locally-best pick. - WHEN: interval
// TEMPLATE 1: Sort by end, compare start
Arrays.sort(intervals, (a, b) -> a[1] - b[1]); // sort by END time
int lastEnd = Integer.MIN_VALUE;
for (int[] interval : intervals) {
    if (interval[0] >= lastEnd) { // start >= lastEnd → no overlap → keep
        lastEnd = interval[1];
        // count++ or add to result
    } else {
        // overlap → skip (or count as removed)
    }
}

// TEMPLATE 2: Sort by start, compare end
Arrays.sort(intervals, (a, b) -> a[0] - b[0]); // sort by START time
List<int[]> result = new ArrayList<>();
for (int[] interval : intervals) {
    if (result.isEmpty() || result.get(result.size()-1)[1] < interval[0]) {
        result.add(interval); // no overlap → new interval
    } else {
        result.get(result.size()-1)[1] =
            Math.max(result.get(result.size()-1)[1], interval[1]); // overlap → extend end
    }
}

// TEMPLATE 3: Sort by start + min-heap of end times (multi-resource)
// USE WHEN counting simultaneous/overlapping resources - "minimum rooms", "max concurrent".
Arrays.sort(intervals, (a, b) -> a[0] - b[0]);
PriorityQueue<Integer> pq = new PriorityQueue<>(); // min-heap of active end times
for (int[] interval : intervals) {
    if (!pq.isEmpty() && pq.peek() <= interval[0])
        pq.poll(); // reuse: earliest-ending resource is free
    pq.offer(interval[1]); // occupy a resource until interval[1]
}
// pq.size() = resources needed

```

Dynamic Programming `dynamic_programming.md`

Six template families. Every problem maps to one loop skeleton and one dp-state definition.

All Six Templates

```
// 1. LINEAR 1D – each cell depends on a fixed number of previous cells
// the answer at i is a fixed recipe over the last one or two answers. – WHEN: "ways/cost to reach ste
int[] dp = new int[n + 1];
dp[0] = base;
for (int i = 1; i <= n; i++)
    dp[i] = f(dp[i-1], dp[i-2], ...);

// 2A. LOOK-BACK 1D – dp[i] depends on all j < i
// to finish position i, scan every earlier position j and extend the best valid one. – WHEN: "longest
int[] dp = new int[n];
for (int i = 0; i < n; i++) {
    for (int j = 0; j < i; j++) {
        dp[i] = f(dp[i], dp[j]); // e.g., LIS, word break
    }
}

// 2B/2C. KNAPSACK – collapse the item dimension to 1D; loop direction picks reuse.
// 0/1 (each item once): j DESCENDING → reads previous row.
// unbounded (reusable): j ASCENDING → reads current row.
// Mnemonic: DESCENDING = Distinct, ASCENDING = Again. Full code + permutation
// variant + "why" in Part 2 – Knapsack DP.

// 3. 2D SEQUENCE – match consumes both, mismatch drops one side. WHEN: LCS / edit
// distance / subsequence count over two strings. Full code → Part 3.
// 4. INTERVAL DP – short ranges first (i right-to-left, j from i+1; dp[i+1][*] ready).
// WHEN: palindrome / merge-burst / split-point in a range. Full code → Part 4.
// 5. GRID DP – each cell accumulates from cells it could arrive from (up/left).
// WHEN: grid paths / min-cost / largest square. Full code → Part 5.
// 6. STATE MACHINE – named states updated from yesterday's states each step.
// WHEN: buy/sell/hold, limited transactions, cooldown/fee. Full code → Part 6.
```

Knapsack Decision Tree

```
Want count or min/max?
├─ Count (dp[j] += dp[j - num])
│   ├── 0/1 (each item once):    j descending → #416, #494
│   └─ Unbounded (reuse):        j ascending → #518
│       └─ Ordered (permut):     target outer, nums inner → #377
└─ Min/Max (dp[j] = min/max(...))
    ├── 0/1 minimize:            j descending → #474 (maximize)
    └─ Unbounded minimize:       j ascending → #322
```

Trie `trie.md`

When to Use Trie (vs HashMap/Array)

Signal	Use
Prefix queries / <code>startsWith</code> / autocomplete	Trie — shares prefixes, prefix lookup is O(k)
Wildcard match (<code>.</code> matches any char)	Trie — DFS branches over children
Prune a search space by shared prefixes (e.g. Word Search II)	Trie — dead branches cut early
Exact-key lookup only (no prefix logic)	HashMap — O(k) hash is simpler and faster, no node overhead

Canonical Template

```
// every node is a shared prefix; walking down spells a word, so common prefixes are stored once. — WH

// — TRIE NODE —
// Array vs Map TrieNode mental model:
// array = O(1) per char, fixed 26 letters, wastes space when sparse
// HashMap = variable alphabet, smaller for sparse, hashing overhead
class TrieNode {
    TrieNode[] children = new TrieNode[26]; // array-based: O(1) access, O(26) per node
    boolean isEnd = false;
}

// Alternative: Map-based (for non-lowercase or variable alphabets)
class TrieNode {
    Map<Character, TrieNode> children = new HashMap<>();
    boolean isEnd = false;
}

// — INSERT —
void insert(TrieNode root, String word) {
    TrieNode node = root;
    for (char c : word.toCharArray()) {
        int idx = c - 'a';
        if (node.children[idx] == null) node.children[idx] = new TrieNode();
        node = node.children[idx];
    }
    node.isEnd = true;
}

// — SEARCH (exact match) —
boolean search(TrieNode root, String word) {
    TrieNode node = root;
    for (char c : word.toCharArray()) {
        int idx = c - 'a';
        if (node.children[idx] == null) return false;
        node = node.children[idx];
    }
    return node.isEnd; // must end at a marked word boundary
}

// — STARTS WITH (prefix match) —
boolean startsWith(TrieNode root, String prefix) {
    TrieNode node = root;
    for (char c : prefix.toCharArray()) {
        int idx = c - 'a';
        if (node.children[idx] == null) return false;
        node = node.children[idx];
    }
    return true; // ← difference from search: don't check node.isEnd
}
```

Variations

```
// VARIATION 1: DFS for wildcard '.' (Add and Search Words)
// When char is '.', try all 26 children recursively instead of following one path.
boolean dfs(TrieNode node, String word, int i) {
    if (i == word.length()) return node.isEnd;
    char c = word.charAt(i);
    if (c == '.') {
        for (TrieNode child : node.children) // ← VARIATION: try all children
            if (child != null && dfs(child, word, i+1)) return true;
        return false;
    }
    int idx = c - 'a';
    if (node.children[idx] == null) return false;
    return dfs(node.children[idx], word, i + 1);
}

// VARIATION 2: early-exit on isEnd (Replace Words – find shortest root)
String findRoot(TrieNode root, String word) {
    TrieNode node = root;
    for (int i = 0; i < word.length(); i++) {
        int idx = word.charAt(i) - 'a';
        if (node.children[idx] == null) return word; // no root found → return original
        node = node.children[idx];
        if (node.isEnd) return word.substring(0, i+1); // ← VARIATION: return at first root hit
    }
    return word;
}

// VARIATION 3: store words at each node (Search Suggestions – top-3 per prefix)
// During insert, each node on the path caches the word (up to 3).
// Products must be inserted in sorted order → first 3 are lexicographically smallest.
void insert(TrieNode root, String word) {
    TrieNode node = root;
    for (char c : word.toCharArray()) {
        int idx = c - 'a';
        if (node.children[idx] == null) node.children[idx] = new TrieNode();
        node = node.children[idx];
        if (node.words.size() < 3) node.words.add(word); // ← VARIATION: cache at every node
    }
    node.isEnd = true;
}

// VARIATION 4: Trie + grid DFS pruning (Word Search II)
// Build Trie from word list. DFS the grid; at each cell, check if current path
// follows a Trie path. Prune entire branch if no Trie node exists.
void dfs(char[][] board, int i, int j, TrieNode node, StringBuilder path, Set<String> result) {
    if (i < 0 || i >= board.length || j < 0 || j >= board[0].length) return;
    char c = board[i][j];
    if (c == '#' || node.children[c - 'a'] == null) return; // ← VARIATION: Trie prune
    node = node.children[c - 'a'];
    path.append(c);
    if (node.isEnd) result.add(path.toString());
    board[i][j] = '#';
    dfs(board, i+1, j, node, path, result);
    dfs(board, i-1, j, node, path, result);
    dfs(board, i, j+1, node, path, result);
    dfs(board, i, j-1, node, path, result);
    board[i][j] = c;
    path.deleteCharAt(path.length() - 1);
}
```

search vs startsWith — One Line Difference

```
search:      return node.isEnd;    // must land on a word boundary
startsWith:  return true;          // any node reached = valid prefix
```

Bit Manipulation `bit_manipulation.md`

Canonical Template

```
// bits are a set/counter — XOR cancels duplicates, AND/OR/shift edit individual bits. — WHEN: "appear
// — XOR CANCEL — pairs cancel; lone element survives
int result = 0;
for (int num : nums) result ^= num;

// — BIT OPERATIONS —
boolean isSet = ((n >> i) & 1) == 1;    // check if bit i is set
int set      = n | (1 << i);           // set bit i
int clear    = n & ~(1 << i);          // clear bit i
int toggle   = n ^ (1 << i);           // toggle bit i
int lowest   = n & (-n);                // isolate lowest set bit
boolean isPow2 = n > 0 && (n & (n-1)) == 0;

// — COUNT SET BITS — Brian Kernighan: each iteration removes one set bit
// WHY n & (n-1) clears the lowest set bit:
//   n      = ...1000 (lowest set bit at this position)
//   n-1    = ...0111 (borrow flips that bit to 0 and all lower bits to 1)
//   n&(n-1)=...0000 (AND keeps higher bits, wipes the lowest set bit + below)
int count = 0;
while (n != 0) { count++; n &= (n - 1); } // n & (n-1) clears lowest set bit

// — BITMASK AS SET — 26-bit integer represents presence of 26 letters
int mask = 0;
for (char c : word.toCharArray()) mask |= (1 << (c - 'a'));
// check no overlap between two words:
if ((mask[i] & mask[j]) == 0) { /* no shared letter */ }
```

Variations

```
// VARIATION 1: mod-3 state machine (Single Number II)
// MENTAL MODEL: extend XOR from mod-2 (cancel pairs) to mod-3 (cancel triples);
//               ones/twos track bits seen 1 or 2 times mod 3.
// Instead of XOR canceling pairs (mod 2), cancel triples (mod 3)
// ones = bits seen exactly 1 mod 3 times; twos = bits seen exactly 2 mod 3 times
int ones = 0, twos = 0;
for (int num : nums) {
    ones = (ones ^ num) & ~twos;    // ← add to ones if not already in twos
    twos = (twos ^ num) & ~ones;    // ← add to twos if not already in ones
}
// After all: ones holds the element appearing once (0 mod 3 remainder = survive)

// VARIATION 2: split XOR into two groups (Single Number III)
// Two unique elements a, b. XOR of all = a ^ b.
// Use lowest set bit of (a^b) to split nums into two groups → each group has one unique.
int xor = 0;
for (int num : nums) xor ^= num;    // xor = a ^ b
int diff = xor & (-xor);            // ← lowest set bit that differs between a and b
int a = 0;
for (int num : nums)
    if ((num & diff) != 0) a ^= num; // ← XOR one group → one unique element
int b = xor ^ a;                    // ← the other unique element

// VARIATION 3: DP relation (Counting Bits)
// dp[i] = dp[i/2] + last bit of i
// i >> 1 = i without last bit (same or fewer ones); last bit = i & 1
int[] dp = new int[n + 1];
for (int i = 1; i <= n; i++)
    dp[i] = dp[i >> 1] + (i & 1);    // ← right-shift halves the problem

// VARIATION 4: common prefix (Bitwise AND of Range)
// AND of any range [left, right]: bits that differ between left and right get cleared.
// Right-shift both until equal → find shared high-bit prefix → shift back.
int shift = 0;
while (left != right) { left >>= 1; right >>= 1; shift++; }
return left << shift;                // ← shift back to original magnitude

// VARIATION 5: carry loop (Sum of Two Integers)
// XOR gives bit sum without carry; AND shifted left gives carry.
// Repeat until no carry remains.
int add(int a, int b) {
    while (b != 0) {
        int carry = a & b;           // ← carry bits
        a = a ^ b;                   // ← partial sum (no carry)
        b = carry << 1;              // ← carry propagated one position left
    }
    return a;
}
```

Design design.md

Canonical Template — HashMap + Doubly Linked List (LRU)

```
// HashMap gives O(1) lookup; the doubly linked list orders by recency so the LRU is always one hop fro

// CacheNode for doubly linked list (named CacheNode to distinguish from ListNode contexts)
class CacheNode {
    int key, value;
    CacheNode previous, next;
    CacheNode(int key, int value) { this.key = key; this.value = value; }
}

// — SENTINEL NODES — head (MRU side) ↔ ... ↔ tail (LRU side)
CacheNode head = new CacheNode(0, 0), tail = new CacheNode(0, 0);
// Initialize: head <-> tail
head.next = tail; tail.previous = head;

// — REMOVE NODE —
void remove(CacheNode node) {
    node.previous.next = node.next;
    node.next.previous = node.previous;
}

// — INSERT AFTER HEAD (= mark as MRU) —
void insertAfterHead(CacheNode node) {
    node.next = head.next;
    node.previous = head;
    head.next.previous = node;
    head.next = node;
}

// — LRU EVICTION — tail.previous is LRU
CacheNode lru = tail.previous;
remove(lru);
map.remove(lru.key);
```

Variations

```
// VARIATION 1: LFU — adds a frequency dimension
// Need: key->value, key->freq, freq->orderedSet<key>, and minFreq
// When a key is accessed: freq++, move from freqToKeys[oldFreq] to freqToKeys[newFreq]
// On eviction: remove first element from freqToKeys[minFreq]
// LinkedHashMap preserves insertion order → oldest at front for same frequency

// VARIATION 2: Insert Delete GetRandom — use array for O(1) random
// ArrayList stores values; HashMap stores val->index in array
// On remove: swap target with last element, update map, remove last
// On getRandom: return list.get(random.nextInt(list.size()))
```

Math `math.md`

Canonical Templates

```
// MENTAL MODEL: number = sequence of digits in some base; iterate by repeatedly
//                  peeling the last digit (% base) and shifting (/ base).
// WHEN: "reverse digits", "x^n", "base conversion", "count primes", "nth divisible-by".

// — DIGIT EXTRACTION LOOP — peel digits right-to-left
while (n != 0) {
    int digit = n % 10; // last digit
    n /= 10;           // drop last digit
    // ... use digit ...
}

// — FAST POWER (exponentiation by squaring) —
// WHY: x^n needs only O(log n) multiplications by squaring the base
//       and consuming one exponent bit per step.
// x^13 = x^8 * x^4 * x^1 (13 = 1101 in binary)
double fastPow(double x, long n) {
    double result = 1;
    while (n > 0) {
        if ((n & 1) == 1) result *= x; // bit set → include this power of x
        x *= x;                       // square the base for the next bit
        n >>= 1;                       // consume one exponent bit
    }
    return result;
}

// — BASE CONVERSION — generic base b, 0-indexed
// number → digits: peel with % b, shift with / b, collect, then reverse
StringBuilder builder = new StringBuilder();
while (num > 0) {
    builder.append(num % b);
    num /= b;
}
builder.reverse();
// digits → number: Horner's rule
int value = 0;
for (int digit : digits) value = value * b + digit;

// — SIEVE OF ERATOSTHENES — mark composites up to n
// WHY start at i*i: any multiple k*i with k < i was already marked by k.
boolean[] composite = new boolean[n];
for (int i = 2; i * i < n; i++) {
    if (composite[i]) continue;
    for (int j = i * i; j < n; j += i) // start at i*i, step by i
        composite[j] = true;
}
```